

VOLUME TWO

Storm Tide

Sankt Annen, 1934–1953

The Reclaimed Land

A North Sea Saga



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Novel · written with Claude Opus

The Reclaimed Land - Storm Tide

Drama / Family and Social Novel

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Chapter 1 - The Heir

Bo Carstens led the farm and the dyke-reeve's office with a competence no one denied him, and with a hardness some indulged him and none named aloud. He was in his mid-twenties when he took over both, and he bore it as if born to it, which in a sense he was: the fifth Carstens on the warft, heir to a farm that under the hereditary farm law was now indivisible and untouchable, grown over five generations, wrested from the sea piece by piece. He knew the dyke like his own body, every metre, every spot — except for the one secret that lay in the chest and that he had overlooked. He walked the inspections strictly, let no weakness through, did not save at the dyke; that his father had impressed on him, with his last clear words: never save at the dyke. Bo kept to it, without knowing why it had been so important to the father, and it made him a good dyke-reeve, whose conscientiousness, like the father's, had a root he did not know.

Grete ran the farm economy, and she ran it well, clear and incorruptible. She had married Bo out of reason and with affection, and she had quickly recognised what he was: a capable, ambitious man who set the farm above all and lost himself in it. She had also recognised what she could not change in him, and she had learned to live with it, as women in the marsh learned to live with what they could not change.

In the stable, in the garden, at the sluice-drain, life went its course, the old course of the marsh, which had changed little in five generations: the cattle, the corn, the tide, the dyke inspection in

spring, the tide season in autumn and winter. But over this old course now lay the new time, the flags, the slogans, the quota, the lists, and Bo was part of it, local farm leader, one who joined in, who carried out, who told himself it was only duty for farm and family.

Thies Feddersen was still on the farm, the last Feddersen, now a man in his forties, landless, a labourer, silent. He worked for Bo, as he had worked for Hauke, and between him and Bo lay the same old silence that had lain between him and Hauke, only the ground was even more unknown to Bo than to himself. Bo saw in Thies only the capable, closed worker who handled the dyke well, better almost than many a farmer; he did not see, or did not want to see, what this man carried in himself, the knowledge of the father who drowned at the spot, the bitterness of forty years.

On the horizon stood the new time, and Bo told himself the joining-in was only duty. He stood on the dyke, that spring of 1934, and looked over his land, and he was content, as far as a man like Bo could be content, who always wanted more. He did not know that he stood on a guilt, and he did not know that the time he was growing into would set him before the same choice his father had stood before: to save his own at the cost of another, and to call the wrong thing the necessary one.

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Chapter 2 - Local Farm Leader

The office of local farm leader was small, measured against what it triggered in Bo. He administered the koog's delivery quota, kept lists of who had to deliver how much, corn, cattle, milk, and he decided, within the limits set him, who was favoured and who was pressed. It was power over the neighbours, and Bo, who had wanted all his life to be something, relished it without admitting it to himself. He called it order. When a smallholder did not meet the quota, Bo pressed him, hard, in the name of the regulation, and told himself he was only doing his duty; the regulation was not his, he only carried it out. It was the same self-deception with which his father had not done the faulty spot — I do only the sensible, the necessary thing — and Bo repeated it, without knowing he repeated it, for he did not know the father's story.

The hardness struck the weakest first, as it always strikes the weakest first. An old cottager who could not raise the quota because he was too ill to work; a widow whose farm was too small. Bo carried out what was prescribed, and rarely softened it, for mercy was not foreseen and made one suspect. Grete saw it and said once, cautiously: "Old Petersen can't deliver, Bo. He's ill. You know it." And Bo said: "The quota is the quota. If I turn a blind eye for one, they all come." It sounded sensible, and it was hard, and Grete was silent, for now.

Thies Feddersen came under pressure. As a labourer, landless, he was suspect anyway in a time that declared the soil sacred and mistrusted the soil-less. There were lists with names like Thies's on

them, people without a farm, without firm ties, and Bo could have protected Thies, with a word, with the surety of the employer. He did the most necessary, no more: certified that Thies was a good worker, indispensable at the dyke. It was enough to keep Thies, and it was as little as it had to be, coldly reckoned, without warmth.

Grete saw the transformation of her husband, slowly, over the months. Bo was not cruel, not by nature; he was ambitious, and the ambition made him compliant, made him one who carried out without asking, who looked away where looking hurt. It was the transformation of many in that time, no special one, and precisely that made it bad: that it was so ordinary, so easy, that a decent man like Bo, a capable farmer, a good dyke-reeve, grew into it, step by step, without ever taking the one great step that would have frightened him.

At the dyke inspection that year Bo showed himself as what he was: a specialist who knew the dyke and held it well. But at one spot, where an expensive, thorough repair would have been needed, he hesitated, reckoned, deferred — and Grete, who walked along, saw it and thought of something she could not name, a family resemblance that went deeper than the features of the face. Bo shunned the expensive precaution, as his father had shunned it, and neither of them knew it was the same thing, and neither knew what it had cost the last time.

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Chapter 3 - Grete

They had married in the crisis, Bo and Grete, in the early thirties, poor and resolute, as one married then. Grete was a farmer's daughter from the neighbouring koog, with a straight gaze and a head that took nothing as given, and Bo had chosen her because she was capable and strong, and she had chosen him because he had a farm and a will, and because between them, besides reason, there was also affection. The first years were hard and good at once, as the first years on a marsh farm often were: much work, little money, but the land bore, and the children came, and Grete made a home of the farmhouse. She was not one to complain. She took hold, stretched the little, made something of nothing, and Bo, who saw her come from the stable with earthy hands or from the sluice-drain with a basket of eels, sometimes thought he had been lucky, luckier than he deserved.

At the wedding Thies Feddersen had been there too, at the edge, as a worker of the farm, not as a guest. And when Bo once stepped out into the cool evening air, Thies stood there smoking, and they were alone for a moment, the son of the man whose father concealed the breach, and the son of the man who drowned at the breach — and Bo knew nothing of either.

"Congratulations, Carstens," said Thies. "Good woman. The Petersens are decent people."

"Thank you," said Bo, a little stiff, for he sensed that something lay between Feddersen and Carstens, an old coldness whose ground he did not know.

Thies smoked and looked at him, long. "You don't know much, do you," he said at last. "About your family. About what was. About the flood."

"What's supposed to be with the flood? That's thirty years ago."

"Ask your father," said Thies, and then it occurred to him that Hauke was dead, and something crossed his face. "Or ask the book. The dyke book. If you can read what's in it." He trod out the cigarette. "Mind yourself in the times that are coming, Carstens. Bad times are coming. And in bad times it shows who a man is. Some families," he looked at Bo, "some families have already shown once what they do when it gets tight. They look away. They save at the wrong end. Mind you don't look away where you ought to look."

Bo did not understand the barb. He heard an embittered labourer making dark hints, and he did not want to understand them, because it was his wedding day. "I don't look away," he said, almost amused. "I have nothing to look away from."

"Everyone has something to look away from," said Thies. "Sooner or later. That's just it." And he went back to his work, and Bo stayed in the evening air, and the sentence stuck in him, without his knowing why, like a stone in the shoe.

Inside, later, Bo thought no more of it. But Grete, who had seen the short conversation from afar, asked him: "What did Thies want?" And Bo said: "Nothing. Old stories. He's embittered, the man, ever since his father drowned, back then in the flood." And Grete remembered the name and the bitterness, and she remembered that there was something between the families that no one spoke of, and she was a woman who remembered things and did not forget.

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Chapter 4 - The Quota

With the rearmament came the pressure on the land. The Reich wanted to be self-sufficient, independent of imports, and that meant: the farmers had to deliver, more and more, and the quota that Bo had to administer rose year by year. It was a screw that slowly tightened, and Bo tightened with it, for that was his office. He collected the quota, even from the poorest, even where it hurt. Old Petersen did not deliver enough, and Bo pressed him, and Petersen finally delivered by giving up his seed corn, and Bo knew that meant the next shortage, and collected it all the same, because the quota was the quota. He told himself he had no choice; the quota came from above, he only carried it out. It was true and was a lie, both at once, as always.

The years of rearmament were good years for Bo's own farm. Prices rose, demand was there, and a hereditary farm, protected and favoured, prospered. A modest prosperity returned, greater than under old Hauke: new implements, a second horse, a further child. Bo rose, and the rise confirmed to him that he was doing right, that joining-in and being-capable paid off, and he did not ask at whose cost the rise came, as little as his father had asked.

The price was the looking-away. People disappeared, here too, in the wide, flat marsh, where one thought oneself far from everything. A neighbour who had talked too loud. A travelling worker who was not the right sort. One lowered the gaze, and Bo lowered it with them, and told himself it was none of his affair, he was a farmer and dyke-reeve, no politician, and what those up there did was not his

business. It was the attitude of most, and it was complicity, and the transition between the two was so fluid that none could name the point at which the one became the other.

Grete held her distance, inwardly. She did not go to the meetings when she could avoid it, did not sing the songs, hung out the flag only when she had to. She held the family together and the children out of the worst, as well as she could, and she saw her husband change and said little, for what should she have said, against the time, against the office, against Bo's conviction that he was only doing his duty.

Once, in those years, on a Sunday, they sat five together in the garden behind the warft, Bo, Grete, the children, and it was a picture of peace: the sun, the growing cabbage, the children playing in the grass. It was a real peace, not a pretended one, an hour of happiness. But over the garden, behind the dyke, lay the water that came and went twice a day, and over the land lay the time that ran toward a war, and Bo sat in his happiness and did not know it was on loan, and that the reckoning would come, as it always came, and that the children who now played in the grass would one day have to pay for what the fathers did and looked away from.

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Chapter 5 - War on the Coast

The war came in 1939, and this time no one marched off with flags and music, at least not in the marsh, where the old still remembered the last one, the names the pastor had read from the pulpit. They were silent when the news came, a silence that knew more than any cheering. The young men went off, from the koog as from everywhere, and the flat land grew empty, emptier still than in the last war. Bo stayed; he was a farmer and dyke-reeve and local farm leader, indispensable, needed where he was. But the work remained, and the hands were lacking: the dyke had to be held, the land tilled, the quota delivered, and all with fewer people, with old men, women, children.

And the quota grew. The war devoured, and the land had to nourish, more and more, and Bo collected it, as he had always collected it, with the hardness of one who tells himself he has no choice. Every repair at the dyke became a question of sacrifice, every sack of corn a duty. Bo manoeuvred, held farm and dyke and office together, and it wore on him, and he grew harder at it, more closed, a man who only functioned.

Then the first foreigners came onto the farms. Prisoners of war first, then the deported from the occupied lands, forced labourers, as one euphemistically called them, as if it were a kind of work and not a kind of slavery. They were assigned to the farms, because the men were lacking, and the Carstens farm too got assigned what was due to it by the size of the holding: hands that were not allowed to ask whether they wanted to.

Bo saw the first come, and he lowered his gaze, as he had learned to lower his gaze. They were people, emaciated, in rags, marked, and Bo treated them as what the system made of them: as tools, as labour, rightless. He told himself it was the war, not him; he had not deported them, he only deployed them, as was prescribed. It was the old self-deception, and it carried Bo, as it had always carried him.

Grete saw the foreigners differently. She saw people, and she saw how they were treated, and something in her rose up, quietly, helplessly. She said nothing before Bo, who had the office and the regulation, but she began, in secret, to do what she could: a piece of bread, a warm soup, secretly, in the dusk, passed to the assigned workers. It was little, and it was dangerous, for whoever helped the forced labourers beyond the prescribed made himself suspect. Grete did it all the same, without ado, as she did everything that had to be done.

And over the marsh lay the war, far off still, at fronts from which only the news came, and the dyke had to be held, and the quota delivered, and the foreigners worked and were silent, and Bo looked away, and Grete looked, and between them grew, unsaid, a difference that would soon become the question before which a human being must decide.

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Chapter 6 - Henryk

Henryk Wójcik came in the spring of 1941, with a transport from the east, and was assigned to the Carstens farm, under Bo. He was nineteen, a slight boy with light eyes and hands that were deft, a farmer's son from a village near Thorn, whom they had dragged off his field, into a marsh he had never heard of, into a language he did not understand, into a labour meant to use him up. On his chest he wore a sign, a sewn-on piece of cloth that marked him as what he was in the language of the time: a man of the second class, a tool. He was not allowed to eat at the family table, not into their house, not into the church. He slept in a chamber over the stable, got less and worse food, and more work, harder. He was rightless, and all knew it, and most behaved accordingly.

Bo was Henryk's master. So the situation was, soberly: a man who as a boy had scuffled with the Feddersen boy, who was good with Grete and carried his children on his shoulders, was now set over another human being like over an animal, with power over his life, and the time demanded that he exercise this power like over an animal.

In the first weeks Bo lowered his gaze. It was his method. He assigned Henryk where there was work, drove him where the quota demanded, and did not look at him while doing it, for to look at him would have meant to see him as a human being, and that Bo could not bear. So he looked away, treated the tool as a tool.

But Henryk would not let himself be quite overlooked. He was a good worker, that was the first thing that penetrated Bo's lowered

gaze: the boy could handle the land, had a feel for the dyke, for the water, learned quickly what was to be done. And he bore a dignity, despite the rags, despite the sign, an uprightness that shone through everything, and precisely it made it hard for Bo to see him as an animal, for animals have no dignity.

Grete passed Henryk food over the stable door. She did it secretly, in the dusk, a piece of bread, a bowl of what was left, and Henryk took it with a look that said more than words. It was dangerous; whoever supplied forced labourers beyond the measure was punished. Grete did it all the same, and she said nothing of it to Bo, because she knew it would burden him, him, the local farm leader, the man with the office.

Bo noticed it all the same. The bread that was missing. Grete's way in the dusk. Her silence about it. And he said nothing, and in his silence lay for the first time not only looking-away, but also something else: a quiet tolerance, almost a gratitude, that his wife did what he did not dare, that in his house someone did the right thing, even if it was not he. It was little. But it was a first crack in his looking-away, a first light, and it came, the way the good often comes, not through him, but through the woman at his side.

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Chapter 7 - On the Ice

It happened in the ice winter of 1942, at the sluice-drain, where the water between koog and outer dyke was regulated. Bo had gone out to check the sluice, for the frost was straining the gates, and the ice stood thick on the drain, and Bo stepped onto it to free an iced-up spot at the weir, and the ice, which looked firm, broke. He sank in, into the ice-cold water, which lamed his limbs at once, and the suck pulled him under the ice, toward the sluice, and for a moment there was the cold clarity of death, the knowledge that in such water one had minutes, no more, that the cold killed faster than the drowning.

Henryk was nearby, at the dyke, and he saw it, and he acted without hesitating. He lay flat on the ice, to spread his weight, and pushed himself forward, to the break, and held Bo out a dyke-batten, which Bo grasped in lying, and pulled, with a strength one would not have credited the slight body, pulled Bo out of the hole, across the ice, onto land. It went quickly and without words, and then they both lay on the firm ground, Bo soaked and blue with cold, and Henryk beside him, gasping.

It was the same scene that had once bound Hauke and Momme, nearly forty years earlier, on the same coast, in the same water: a man who pulled another out of the water. The water repeated itself, the way it always repeated itself, and put to Bo the same question it had once put to his father: what do you owe the one who saved your life?

Bo looked at Henryk, for the first time really looked at him, the boy who had just saved him, him, the master, the man of the system

that had deported Henryk. Henryk could have watched the ice pull Bo under; no one would have held it against him, no one could have proved it against him. Instead he had saved him, out of a reflex of humanity that sat deeper than all circumstances, and in this reflex lay an accusation sharper than any reproach: Henryk had shown himself a human being in the moment when Bo treated him as a tool.

"Dziękuję," said Bo, the one Polish word he had picked up, thank you, and it was the first time he addressed Henryk like a human being.

Henryk only nodded, curtly, and helped Bo up, for Bo had to get into the warmth, quickly, before the cold took him after all. In the weeks that followed Bo did what he could, which was little and dangerous. He assigned Henryk the lighter work where it was possible. He slipped him bread, secretly, as Grete did, the Bo-bread to the Grete-bread. He turned a blind eye to small offences. It was a requital in small things, an attempt to pay off the debt of his life, and it was as insufficient as Hauke's charity once was, a means of living with one's own complicity, more than a real making-good.

Grete saw the change and was glad and worried at once. "Be careful," she said. "They see everything. If they notice you're sparing him, it's worse for him and for you too." And then, more quietly: "But if you help him, then help him properly. Half helps no one. Half is only for your conscience." And Bo knew she was right, as she was always right, and he feared the day when the half would no longer suffice, when he would have to choose, wholly, as his father had once had to choose.

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Chapter 8 - The February Flood

It came in February 1943, a heavy storm tide, at northwest storm and high tide, and the whole koog was called to dyke watch, as ever, every man to his section. But there were few men, for the war had taken them, and so was called up whoever was there: old men, half-grown boys — and the forced labourers, who, rightless as they were, could be set at the most dangerous spots without anyone asking. Bo divided the watches. It was his duty as dyke-reeve to distribute them, and there was a spot that was softened, dangerous, where the water pressed, a spot that needed an experienced, alert man — or one whom one could burn through, if it went wrong. And Bo, under the pressure of the night, with too few hands, before the choice of setting a farmer or a forced labourer at the spot, said: "Henryk. You take the spot at the weir. You know it."

It was true, Henryk knew the spot. And it was a pretext, for the true reckoning was a different one: if the spot held, it was good; if it did not hold, it was a forced labourer, no farmer, no son of the koog. Bo did not think it so clearly. He would never have dared to think it so clearly. But beneath the words, there where a man decides before he knows he has decided, the reckoning was already made, the same reckoning his father had made when he set Momme at the faulty spot.

Bo could have done it otherwise. He could have set Henryk at a safe spot, the one who had saved his life, to whom he owed everything. He could have set himself at the dangerous spot. He did not. He set Henryk at the spot at the weir, and Henryk went, through

the storm, without contradiction, for a forced labourer had no contradiction, and Bo watched him go, and in him was a pull he knew and would not name.

In the night, at the peak of the flood, the spot at the weir gave way. Not wholly, not to a breach as in 1906; the dyke held, barely, because one stacked sandbags in time. But the water took what stood at the spot, in a moment when a breaker washed over the dyke, and that was Henryk. They found him in the morning, a stretch inland, in the silt, where the water had carried him, as it had once carried Momme.

Bo stood in the morning at the spot, and it was the same knowledge his father had carried that he now carried: he had saved his own, a farmer, a son of the koog, by setting another at the dangerous spot, one who had saved his life, to whom he owed everything. He could have spared him. He had not done it. And no one would ever call him to account for it, for it had only been a forced labourer, a war-dead among millions, died in the dyke service, no one's guilt, an act of God, the war.

Bo was sick at the dyke, bent over, retched up the bile, as his father had been sick, forty years earlier, on the same coast, after a different flood. The body knew what the head talked itself out of. The apple had not fallen far. The Carstenses saved themselves and let the other fall, and the water had written the story a second time, almost word for word, and Bo knelt in the silt beside the dead boy who had pulled him from the ice, and knew that he now carried what his father had carried, unnamed, unprovable, all his life.

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Chapter 9 - No One Asks

Henryk's death made no waves. A dead forced labourer counted for nothing in those years; he was recorded, briefly, in a list, died in the dyke service, and buried, without a cross, without a name, at the edge of the cemetery, where one buried the foreigners. No one asked how he had come to the dangerous spot, no one asked whether it could have been otherwise. It was war, and in war people died, and one forced labourer more or less did not stand out. Bo told himself, the way such things let themselves be told: it had been the storm, the water, the breaker, not him. He had only divided, the way one had to divide, with too few men, in a heavy night. Henryk had known the spot. It had been a sensible assignment. So Bo told himself, and it helped him by day, when he worked, and it did not help him at night, when he lay awake and heard the water and saw the boy before him who had pulled him from the ice.

Grete knew what had happened. She had heard the assignment, she had seen Bo set Henryk at the spot, and she had looked at Bo when they found Henryk, and read everything in his face. She said nothing. What should she have said. But between her and Bo there now grew a second silence, beside the inherited one, of which she knew nothing — a silence about Henryk, that laid itself onto the silence about the old flood, that lay in the chest, in the dyke book, unread. Two silences, one upon the other, the way the silt lays itself layer upon layer over the land.

Thies Feddersen, the old labourer, looked at Bo in those days, the way he had once looked at Hauke. Thies knew nothing exact — he

had not heard the assignment, did not know the circumstances — but he saw Bo's face, the grey, closed face after the flood, and he recognised something in it, a resemblance that made him shiver. "Your family," he said once, in passing, while clearing the dyke, without looking at Bo, "your family has its own relation to the water. It never takes you. It always takes the one beside you." And he walked on, and Bo stayed standing with the spade in his hand, and the sentence struck him like a blow, because it was true and Thies could not know how true.

Bo did not quite understand what Thies meant, and yet he sensed it. It always takes the one beside you. Momme, back then. Henryk, now. And between them the Carstenses, who survived, who gained, who rose. Bo leafed that night again in the dyke book, which lay in the chest, sought the old entry of 1906, read it once more — the faulty spot, patched and not done, the dyke-reeve warned —, and this time he came nearer the truth, sensed the connection, sensed that his father had done or left undone something that had to do with Momme's death. But he did not think it to the end. He was tired, and the war was not yet over, and he had enough to carry himself. He shut the book and laid it back, and that was his part of the silence: that he held the truth twice in his hand and twice laid it back.

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Chapter 10 - The Treks

In the winter of 1945 the treks came. From the east, over the ice, over the destroyed roads, they came, the refugees, hundreds of thousands, and a part of the stream reached the coast too, the marsh, the flat land at the end of the Reich. They came with horse-wagons, with handcarts, with what they could carry, women, children, old people, for the men were in the field or dead, and they sought a roof, a piece of bread, a place. The king had to take them in. It was ordered, and it was also unavoidable without an order, for the people were there, stood before the farms, exhausted, half-frozen, and one could not leave them standing in the snow. Onto every farm came billetings, and onto the Carstens farm too, which was large and had room.

Bo hesitated. Not from hard-heartedness alone, but from the reckoning that had become his nature: the foreigners ate along, needed room, and times were tight. But Grete did not hesitate. She took in a family, a mother with three children from East Prussia, whose husband was missing, and she gave them the chamber and shared the food, without asking, without reckoning. "They have nothing, Bo," she said. "We have a roof. That's all that counts." And Bo, who reckoned, was silent before Grete's clarity, which did not reckon.

It was the same difference as with Henryk: Grete saved, where Bo reckoned. She did the human thing, simply, without ado, and Bo saw it and could not do it, and in the seeing lay a confession he did not confess to himself: that his wife was of a wood he did not have, that

she did the right thing where he did the sensible thing, and that the sensible thing was often the wrong one.

With the treks came the end too. The war collapsed, the front came nearer, then the British were there, took over the control, and the old order of the marsh, the order of the flags and slogans and the hereditary farm law, that fell apart overnight. The hereditary farm law was abolished; the farm was no longer untouchable, no longer sacred, only a farm, a large farm on the coast whose owner had been local farm leader.

And that was what Bo now feared. He was compromised, he knew that: local farm leader, member, one who had collected the quota and joined in. The British and the new administration would ask who had been what, and Bo would have to answer. And there was one who knew what Bo had been, who could incriminate him: Thies Feddersen, the landless labourer, who had been on the farm all those years and had seen everything, the quota-collecting, the looking-away, perhaps more. Thies Feddersen, the son of the man who had drowned at the faulty spot of the Carstenses, forty years ago. He of all people would now, perhaps, decide over Bo's fate.

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Chapter 11 - Denazification

The committee sat in the county town, and Bo sat before it, on a chair, like an accused, and it was, he thought, a strange reversal: all his life he had sat behind the table, with the list, the quota, and decided over others. Now others sat behind the table, and on their list stood he. They read out what they knew about him: local farm leader, member, responsible for the delivery quota, master of forced labourers. It sounded bad and was the usual; many in the marsh had done the same, and one could not punish all, so one asked after the degree, after witnesses, whether one had been a slave-driver or only a follower who carried out what all carried out.

Then they called Thies Feddersen.

Bo saw him enter, the old labourer, who had worked forty years on the farms of the Carstenses, first at Hauke's, then at his, the son of the man who drowned at the faulty spot. Thies knew more about the Carstenses than anyone. He had seen the quota-collecting, the looking-away, the years of joining-in. And perhaps he knew more about Henryk than Bo thought; perhaps he had seen something, heard, sensed. A man like Thies, who bore forty years of bitterness against the Carstenses, now had the chance to take revenge, with a few sentences, before a committee that listened to witnesses.

Thies spoke. He spoke briefly, factually, without hatred, which was worse than hatred. He said what was: that Bo had been local farm leader, that he had collected the quota, hard sometimes. He said it soberly, without exaggerating. And when the chairman asked

whether Bo Carstens had been a particularly zealous, a particularly hard one, one who had done more than ordered — there Thies paused, long, and Bo held his breath.

There a woman stepped forward, a refugee woman whom Grete had taken in, and she testified about the house of Carstens: that the farmwife, Grete, had given her and her children the roof, shared the bread, without asking, when they had nothing. And another voice, from somewhere, testified that food had come from the house of Carstens to the forced labourers, secretly, at risk — Grete's bread, over the stable door, to Henryk and the others.

Thies heard that, and it changed something in his face. He could have stayed with the incriminating. Instead he said, and it visibly cost him something: "If bread came from the house for the foreigners, then the woman risked more than most here. And if bread comes from a house, not everything in it is rotten." He looked at Bo. "I have nothing in hand against Bo Carstens that would make him a slave-driver. He was a follower like a hundred others. No better. But no worse either."

It was no defence. It was a bitter justice, a truth, no more and no less, and it sufficed for survival, not for acquittal. The committee classified Bo as a follower, with a fine, a ban on public offices that lapsed after years. Bo was allowed to stay, allowed to keep the farm, allowed to go on living in the marsh. His civic life was saved, by his wife's bread and the truthfulness of a man who had every reason to destroy him.

After the session, in the corridor, Thies stepped to him once more. They stood alone, the son of the drowned man and the follower, and Thies looked at him, long, and said quietly, only for Bo: "I told the truth, Carstens, no more. It helped you, this time. But don't confuse it

with forgiveness. Your guilt I do not take from you. It lies in the land. Ask the land. Ask the book in your chest. It knows more than I." And he went, the old man, and Bo stayed in the corridor, survived, saved, and more heavily laden than before, for now he knew that Thies knew something about the book, about the old flood, and that the guilt was older than his own failure and reached deeper, to the father, to the faulty spot at which Thies's father drowned.

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Chapter 12 - Rebuilding

The postwar years came, and the marsh ordered itself anew, slowly, laboriously. The hunger stayed a while yet, the scarcity, the barter, but the land nourished, as it had always nourished, and that was the advantage of the marsh over the bombed cities: whoever had land had bread. Bo lost the dyke-reeve's office; the ban forbade him the public office, and a man with his past could not be dyke-reeve in the new time. He stayed a farmer, worked the farm, and the loss of the office humiliated and freed him at once, in a strange way. For without the office, without the list, without the small power, Bo was again nearer to what he originally was: a farmer, a man who worked with his hands, and in the shared work at the dyke, at the rebuilding, he found something of the old comradeship he had lost as an office-holder.

Democracy came into the koog, new dyke associations, elected representatives, a say. It was unaccustomed, after the years of command, and many an old man grumbled, but it prevailed, and Bo, who was no longer allowed an office, watched from outside how the koog ordered itself anew, freer, louder, more contentious.

Grete held the family together, through the scarcity, through the humiliation, as she had held it through the war. The refugee family stayed a while, then moved on, into the west, where there was work, and left gratitude behind and a gap. The children grew, into a new, more open time, a time that was other than the one Bo had grown up in, and Bo saw it with a mixture of relief and strangeness.

Thies Feddersen worked a few more years, then he grew too old. He died in the early fifties, the last Feddersen of his generation, alone, without land, without a farm, the son of the man who drowned at the faulty spot, who had worked forty years on the farms of the Carstenses and knew their guilt and had never been able to prove it. Bo went to his burial, as Hauke had once gone to the burial of the Feddersen widow, and stood at the back, and it was as if that too repeated itself, as if history were a tidal flow that always casts the same images onto the shore.

But Thies had descendants. A daughter who had moved away, and through her the line of the Feddersens would go on, thin, distant, but not extinguished, and one distant day a Feddersen would come back to the coast, as a Carstens would come back, and the two lines, which had never greeted each other, would meet again at the old place, at the dyke, at the water, at the spot where long ago a man drowned.

Bo, aged, prematurely aged by the war and by what he carried, stayed on the farm, a simple farmer now, and the dyke book stayed in the chest, with the entry he had read twice and not quite understood and yet sensed. And over the marsh life went on, poorer and freer at once, and before the dyke lay the old foreland under water, with the sunken Feddersen warft, and the water came and went, twice a day, patient, and remembered what the people forgot.

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Chapter 13 - The Son Who Stays

Bo had two children who reached adulthood: a son, Hinrich, and a daughter, Anke. And in them showed, as it always showed in the children of this family, the old division: the one who stays and preserves, the other who goes away and asks. Hinrich was the preserver. He was diligent, dutiful, down-to-earth, a boy who wanted the farm and the dyke, who wanted to be nothing other than a farmer in the marsh, like his father, like the grandfather. He went early to the field and the dyke, learned to read the water, took on responsibility, and Bo saw in him the heir, the one who would carry on the farm, undivided, into the next generation. Hinrich did not ask after the old story; what was past was past, and the book in the chest did not interest him. He was no brooder. He was a doer, and that pleased Bo and it also disquieted him, for he recognised in it his own looking-away, his own inability to look where it hurt.

Anke was different. She was clever, headstrong, curious in a way one did not like to see in girls, and she wanted to go away: to learn, to become something, out of the marsh, out of the narrow life at the dyke. She read, she asked, she was not satisfied with the answers of the grown-ups. And she sensed, with the fine ear of those who want to leave, that over the farm lay a silence, something unspoken, an old story that no one talked about. She once asked after the flood, after the Feddersens, after the name that sometimes fell and was quickly wiped away again, and Bo evaded, as his father had evaded, and Anke remembered the evading, the way one remembers pieces of

evidence.

Grete fostered Anke's headstrongness, against the resistance of the koog, which held that a girl belonged at the farm and not in the school of the city. "Let her learn," said Grete to Bo. "Nothing holds her here. And perhaps it's good if one of the family looks outward, further than to the dyke." Bo gave way, the way men in the marsh gave way when the women were right and did not say it loud, and Anke went away, to the city, to school, and came back another, in the holidays, and brought questions with her that no one in the koog asked.

So the siblings divided the inheritance, the way the inheritances in this family always divided: Hinrich, who would stay and preserve the farm and the silence, untouched; Anke, who went away and asked and saw the world from outside. And between the two, the preserver and the questioner, would be decided — a generation later, through Anke's children, through Hinrich's children — what became of the breach Hauke had made and Bo had repeated. For Anke would have a daughter who would be called Wiebke, and Wiebke would come back, not as a farmwife, but as an engineer, and she would read the water as the Carstenses had always read it, only with other eyes, and she would open the book that lay in the chest.

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Chapter 14 - Land Under, Land Over

The fifties brought the upswing, and they brought it to the coast too, in the shape of machines. Where earlier human hands had dug the silt from the watt, stuck the groynes, thrown the clay onto the dyke, now came excavators, pumps, machines that did in days what one had earlier needed weeks and many hands for. The land reclamation, the old, patient work of generations, was mechanised, accelerated, and new kooogs grew into the sea, faster than ever before. Bo, aged, saw the machines come and felt what old men feel when the world changes: a mixture of wonder and strangeness. He had held the dyke with his hands, all his life, with spade and faggots and the strength of many men, and now a machine did it faster and with fewer people, and it was progress, and it took something from the work that Bo could not name: the comradeship perhaps, the knowledge that one depended on one another.

But the old foreland of 1906 stayed as it was: undyked, given over to the water. One could have reclaimed it, with the new machines, could have dyked it in, the deep stretch in which the sunken Feddersen warft lay. But it did not pay; the land was too deep, too salted, and there was easier land to gain elsewhere. So the foreland stayed outside, a stretch of watt and salt-meadow before the dyke, with the remains of the Feddersen warft that no one saw any more, that only the very old knew and of which the young did not even know that a farm had once stood there.

In those years Bo began to want to say something to a grandchild. Anke had married, in the west, and brought in the holidays a child

along, a little girl, curious like the mother, and the child asked after everything, also after the water before the dyke, after the stretch where the watt was. "There was land there once," said Bo. "Earlier. Long ago. A farm stood there." And the child asked: "Who lived there?" And Bo said: "Feddersen. The Feddersens lived there." And he wanted to say more, wanted to tell, of the flood, of Momme, of the spot — and he broke off, as his father had broken off. "Come," he said. "It's getting cold." And took the child by the hand and went back to the warft.

The child, though, remembered the name, Feddersen, and the stretch of water where a farm had stood, and it remembered that the grandfather had wanted to say something and had not said it. It was Anke's daughter, and she was not yet called Wiebke — that would be only a generation later — but she carried the curiosity on, the not-forgetting, the asking, and through her it would go on, the thread that led from the grandfather's broken sentence to the granddaughter's opened book, across the years, patient, as the water was patient that lay before the dyke and waited.

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Chapter 15 - The Dyke Book, Found Again

It was while clearing out the chest, on a grey day in autumn, that Bo took the dyke book in hand again, really in hand, not just a fleeting leafing. Grete had said the old chest had to be cleared out, it took up room and was full of old junk, and Bo had sat down and gone through what a hundred years of farm history had gathered: leases, parish-register entries, yellowed letters — and the dyke book, the heavy, leather-bound book that Hauke had taken over from Okke and Bo from Hauke. This time Bo read the entry of 1906 fully, slowly, with the eyes of a man who now knew himself what it meant to leave a spot undone at the dyke, to set a person at a dangerous spot. He read: the faulty spot by the sluice. Patched and not thoroughly done. The dyke-reeve warned. Date. Okke's hand. And beneath it, what Bo had earlier overlooked, a second note, briefer, in the same hand: after the breach. A dead man at the said spot: M. Feddersen, who had the watch.

And now what Bo had known in fragments all his life fitted together. His father Hauke, dyke-reeve in 1906, had known the faulty spot and not had it done, out of thrift. The dyke broke at this spot. And at the spot Momme Feddersen died, who guarded it — Thies's father. Hence the bitterness of the Feddersens. Hence the silence. Hence the father had wanted to speak of the spot at his deathbed and had not been able to. On that, on this concealed omission, stood the farm, the won land, the whole prosperity of the Carstenses.

Bo sat long still with the book. And he saw, with a clarity that made him colder than the autumn day, the repetition: what his father

had done to Momme, he had done to Henryk. A faulty, a dangerous spot. A man one set there. A dead man who saved one's own. And a silence about it that one carried on. The apple had not fallen far. Two generations, the same guilt, almost word for word, and the book in his hand proved the first and sensed the second.

Bo wrestled with the book, as his father had once wrestled with it. He could tear out the page, erase the truth, destroy the last testimony — and with it the possibility that anyone would ever learn what the farm stood on. Or he could leave it, pass it on, as Hauke had passed it on. He took the page between his fingers.

And he left it. Like his father he left it standing, the entry, the truth, and he did not quite know why, only that he could not do it, destroy the page, as little as he could speak the truth. Perhaps it was cowardice. Perhaps it was something else, something that was almost hope: that one day there would be a human being, braver than he, braver than his father, who opened the book and read and said what two generations had concealed. He laid the book back in the chest, and Grete saw him do it, saw his face, and she knew that he now carried both: the father's guilt, which he had finally understood, and his own, which so resembled the first.

"You read it," said Grete quietly. It was not a question.

"I read it," said Bo. And they said no more, for there was no more to say, and the silence that now lay between them was fuller than any word: the knowledge of two people of two guilts, the one old, the other fresh, and both enclosed in a chest, in a book, in a land that let nothing be forgotten.

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Chapter 16 - What the Land Holds

Bo grew old on the farm, prematurely aged by all he carried, and in his last years he often went to the dyke, to the sluice, where Hauke had stood, and looked over the land and over the water that lay before the dyke, over the old foreland with the sunken wall. Henryk's death sat in him as 1906 had sat in Hauke, and with the years it grew not lighter but heavier, for an old man has time to remember, and the forgetting that work grants the younger, age grants no more. He saw the boy before him who had pulled him from the ice, and he saw how he set him at the spot at the weir, and no year made that better.

Once, in those last years, when Anke's daughter was visiting again, the curious child, already bigger now, almost a young woman, Bo sat with her at the dyke, and he began to tell. "There was one," he said. "In the war. One who worked for us. Henryk was his name. He saved my life, on the ice. And I —" He faltered. The young woman looked at him, waiting, and Bo felt the sentence rise, the whole sentence this time, the truth about Henryk, about the February flood, about the spot. And behind it, older, the other truth, about the father, about Momme, about the book in the chest.

"And you what, Grandpa?" she asked.

And Bo broke off. It was too big. It was too heavy. And she was young, he told himself, one must not lay such a thing on a young person. It was a pretext, and a part of him knew it, the old Carstens pretext, rather keep the heavy than speak it. "I couldn't help him," said Bo. "The war. The water. One couldn't help many." And he took

the young woman by the hand. "Come. It's getting cold."

But she did not quite let it drop, the young woman, Anke's daughter, Wiebke's mother. She remembered the name Henryk, and the broken sentence, and the word "faulty spot" that Bo had once muttered in half-sleep, and she would pass it on, without knowing it, to her own daughter, who would one day come back to the coast.

Bo died in his late years, at the window from which one saw the dyke, and Grete found him in the morning, his face finally calm. He had never said the word, neither word, neither about Henryk nor about the father. He took it with him, almost whole. Almost. For in the chest lay the dyke book, with the entry, and in the young woman lay the memory of a broken sentence, and that was enough, just enough, that it could one day break open.

The modernisation marched on, the koog grew safer, the dykes higher, the machines mightier, and the marsh forgot faster than it had forgotten before. But before the dyke still lay the calm, treacherous water over the old foreland, and it came and went, twice a day, and remembered what the people forgot, and waited, patient, for a time not yet born — a time in which the water would rise, higher than ever, and reclaim what one had taken from it, and lay bare what one had hidden in it.

Über dieses Buch

The Reclaimed Land - Storm Tide

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